

Month Cycle Table Rulebook

This document describes the finished rules used by the current version of the game.

1. Overview

Month Cycle Table is a 4-player draw-discard card game built around a 96-card custom deck.

Core flow:

- each player normally holds 5 total cards
- on your turn, you draw to 6
- if those 6 cards form a legal winning pattern, you may win
- otherwise you discard back to 5
- other players may claim that discard in priority order
- scoring uses exactly one 6-card winning pattern

The game is built around:

- Month : 1 to 12
- Color : G , R , Y , K , B , W
- Wind : N , S , E , W
- each month-color card has a unique month-color identity
- each wind-color card has a unique wind-color identity and no month

2. Components

The deck has 96 unique cards.

2.1 Month Cards (72 cards)

Each month card has:

- a month from 1 to 12
- a color: G , R , Y , K , B , or W

Month order is linear and does not wrap. Month 12 and month 1 are not neighboring or consecutive.

Deck structure:

- months repeat every 12 cards
- the 72 month cards cover all 12 months across all 6 colors: G, R, Y, K, B, W
- each month appears exactly 6 times in the deck
- each color appears exactly 12 times among month cards

2.2 Wind Cards (24 cards)

Each wind card has:

- a wind: N (North), S (South), E (East), or W (West)
- a color: G, R, Y, K, B, or W
- **no month**

Wind cards participate in color-based requirements but cannot satisfy month-based requirements.

3. Players, Seats, and Dealer

The game uses exactly 4 players:

- East
- South
- West
- North

At the start of a new match:

- all players begin with 18 points
- a random dealer is chosen
- that dealer becomes East

Seat wind (home wind):

- East player's home wind is E
- South player's home wind is S
- West player's home wind is W
- North player's home wind is N

Dealer rule:

- if East wins the hand, East remains dealer for the next hand
- otherwise dealer passes to the next player

East starts each hand, but East does not receive a special scoring bonus.

4. Match Structure

A match lasts up to 12 rounds.

Round flow:

- rounds are numbered 1 through 12
- after round 12, if one player leads, the match ends
- if round 12 ends in a tie for first, the game enters sudden death
- sudden death continues until the tie breaks

Early match end:

- if any player falls to 0 points or below, the match ends immediately

5. Hand Setup

At the start of each hand:

- shuffle all 96 cards
- deal 5 cards to each player
- the remaining 76 cards become the wall
- East takes the first turn

6. Hand Structure

Each player has:

- a concealed hand
- an open area

For win checking, a player's total hand is:

- concealed cards + open cards

Important:

- only concealed cards may be discarded
- open cards stay face-up and locked for the rest of the hand
- before drawing or claiming, a player should normally have 5 total cards

- after drawing or claiming, they temporarily have 6

7. Turn Flow

On your turn:

1. Draw 1 card from the wall.
2. You now have 6 total cards.
3. If the 6-card hand forms a legal winning pattern, you may declare *tsumo*.
4. If you do not win, discard 1 concealed card.
5. Other players may respond to that discard.
6. If no claim succeeds, the next player takes a turn.

A player may pass a legal *tsumo* and keep playing.

8. Claims

After a discard, claims are checked in this order:

1. *ron*
2. *kan*
3. *pon*
4. *chi*

If a higher-priority claim succeeds, lower-priority claims do not happen.

8.1 Ron

Ron means winning on another player's discard.

Rules:

- if adding the discarded card to your current total hand creates a legal winning 6-card pattern, you may *ron*
- multiple players may *ron* the same discard
- each *ron* winner is paid separately by the discarder

8.2 Chi

Chi is not a sequence claim in this game.

Rules:

- only the next player in turn order may **chi**
- no sequence is required
- **chi** simply takes the discarded card and places it into your open area
- after **chi** , you must discard one concealed card

Because **chi** opens exactly one visible card, it is the smallest way to build gear.

8.3 Pon

Pon is month-based for month cards and wind-based for wind cards.

Rules for month cards:

- you may **pon** only if you already have exactly **3** cards of the same month as the discard across your concealed and open cards
- all of those same-month cards, plus the claimed discard, become open
- after **pon** , you must discard one concealed card

Rules for wind cards:

- you may **pon** only if you already have exactly **3** cards of the same wind as the discard across your concealed and open cards
- all of those same-wind cards, plus the claimed discard, become open
- after **pon** , you must discard one concealed card

In practice, **pon** creates an open block of **4** visible cards.

8.4 Kan

Kan is also month-based for month cards and wind-based for wind cards.

Rules for month cards:

- you may **kan** only if you already have exactly **4** cards of the same month as the discard across your concealed and open cards
- all of those same-month cards, plus the claimed discard, become open
- after **kan** , you must discard one concealed card

Rules for wind cards:

- you may **kan** only if you already have exactly **4** cards of the same wind as the discard across your concealed and open cards

- all of those same-wind cards, plus the claimed discard, become open
- after **kan** , you must discard one concealed card

In practice, **kan** creates an open block of 5 visible cards.

8.5 Self Kan

On your own turn, you may also declare a **self kan** .

Rules for month cards:

- if your concealed hand contains 5 cards of the same month, you may open them immediately as a **kan**
- after **self kan** , you must discard 1 concealed card

Rules for wind cards:

- if your concealed hand contains 5 cards of the same wind, you may open them immediately as a **kan**
- after **self kan** , you must discard 1 concealed card

In practice, **self kan** converts a concealed 5-card block into an open 5-card block without needing an opponent discard.

9. Wind Discard Rules

9.1 Home Wind Discard

When you discard your **home wind** (the wind matching your seat):

- **ron** is checked first
- if no player wins by **ron** , you **may** choose to move one concealed card from your hand to your open area
- if you do, that opened card is placed face-up before **kan** , **pon** , or **chi** respond to the discarded wind
- opponents may claim the discarded wind card via **ron** , **kan** , **pon** , or **chi**
- opponents **may not** claim the card you just opened
- if you have no concealed cards other than the wind you are discarding, you may skip the optional open

9.2 Matching Card Discard

When you discard a card and still have another concealed card with the same group:

- same group means the same month number for month cards
- same group means the same wind for wind cards
- **ron** is checked first
- if no player wins by **ron**, you **may** choose to move one matching concealed card from your hand to your open area
- only a matching concealed card may be opened this way
- the opened matching card is placed face-up before **kan**, **pon**, or **chi** respond to the discarded card
- opponents may claim the discarded card via **ron**, **kan**, **pon**, or **chi**
- opponents **may not** claim the card you just opened

Examples:

- if you discard a month **7** and still hold another month **7**, you may open one held month **7**
- if you discard **N** and still hold another **N**, you may open one held **N**
- if you discard a month **7**, you may not open a month **5**

9.3 Guest Wind Discard

When you discard a wind card that is **not** your home wind:

- the discard proceeds normally
- no additional effects apply

10. Winning

There are two win methods:

- **Tsumo** : win on your own draw
- **Ron** : win on another player's discard

A winning hand is always exactly **6** total cards.

If a 6-card hand matches more than one pattern:

- remove any pattern that fails the gear rule
- from the remaining valid patterns, apply any gear-based point reduction
- use the highest-point result after gear is applied

10.1 Wind Card Pattern Restrictions

Wind cards have **no month**. Therefore, wind cards cannot be used in any pattern that requires month properties, including:

- Skip
- Run
- Triple Pair
- Twin Tone Pairs
- Parity Pairs
- Twin Triples
- Tri Tone Triples
- Parity Triples
- Escort
- Split Escort
- Mono Skip
- Mono Run

Wind cards **can** be used in **Mono** (all same color), **Axis**, **Grand Axis**, **Tempest**, **Grand Tempest**, and all wind-specific patterns listed in Section 15.

11. Gear Rule

Gear is based on the literal number of visible open cards in your open area. Some higher-value sets can still score with lower gear, but they score as a smaller point tier until you have enough open cards.

Current gear requirements:

- **3pt** requires at least **3** open cards
- **6pt** requires at least **3** open cards
 - with exactly **3** open cards, it scores **3pt**
 - with **4** or more open cards, it scores the full **6pt**
- **9pt** requires at least **3** open cards
 - with exactly **3** open cards, it scores **3pt**
 - with exactly **4** open cards, it scores **6pt**
 - with **5** open cards, it scores the full **9pt**
- **12pt** is always valid, but gear changes the score
 - with **0** to **3** open cards, it scores **6pt**
 - with exactly **4** open cards, it scores **9pt**
 - with **5** open cards, it scores the full **12pt**
- **15pt** is always valid, but gear changes the score
 - with **0** to **3** open cards, it scores **9pt**

- with exactly 4 open cards, it scores 12pt
- with 5 open cards, it scores the full 15pt

This applies to both:

- tsumo
- ron

Examples:

- one chi gives 1 open card
- two chi claims give 2 open cards
- one pon usually gives 4 open cards
- one kan usually gives 5 open cards
- a home wind discard with optional open gives 1 open card
- a matching-card discard with optional open gives 1 open card

12. Round Bonus

Each round has a target month equal to the round number.

Examples:

- round 1 targets month 1
- round 5 targets month 5
- round 12 targets month 12

Bonus rule:

- if you win in round N
- and your final winning 6-card hand contains month N
- you gain +3 points once

Important:

- the bonus applies only once per winning hand
- it applies to both tsumo and ron
- it can raise a 15pt hand to 18pt
- sudden death rounds do not have a numbered month target

13. Home Wind Bonus

If your winning 6-card hand contains your **home wind** (the wind matching your seat), you gain **+3** points once.

Important:

- the bonus applies only once per winning hand
- it applies to both **tsumo** and **ron**
- it stacks with the round month bonus
- a **15pt** hand with both bonuses scores **21pt**

14. Settlement

14.1 Tsumo

On **tsumo** :

- the winner gains the hand's full value
- the other **3** players each pay one third of that value

Because all legal totals are divisible by **3** , settlement is always clean.

Examples:

- **3pt** tsumo: each opponent pays **1**
- **12pt** tsumo: each opponent pays **4**
- **18pt** tsumo: each opponent pays **6**
- **21pt** tsumo: each opponent pays **7**

14.2 Ron

On **ron** :

- the discarder pays the full value
- the winner gains the full value

14.3 Multiple Ron

If multiple players **ron** the same discard:

- each winner scores separately
- the discarder pays each winner in full

15. Winning Patterns

All patterns below use exactly 6 cards.

15.1 3-point patterns

Pattern	Requirement	Gear
Mono	All 6 cards share one color	At least 3 open cards
Skip	All 6 cards are all odd months or all even months, all 6 months are different, and all 6 colors are different	At least 3 open cards
Run	Six different months in order; if any of those cards are open, the open months must also be consecutive within the run	At least 3 open cards
Wind	All 6 cards are wind cards, with all 6 colors present	At least 3 open cards

15.2 6-point patterns

Pattern	Requirement	Gear
Triple Pair	3 pairs from 3 consecutive months	3 open cards scores 3pt; 4+ open cards scores 6pt
Wind Pairs	3 pairs from 3 different winds	3 open cards scores 3pt; 4+ open cards scores 6pt
Axis	Either: 2 of your seat wind plus 4 of the current round month; or 4 of your seat wind plus 2 of the current round month	3 open cards scores 3pt; 4+ open cards scores 6pt
Twin Tone Pairs	3 pairs from 3 different months, using at most 2 colors total	3 open cards scores 3pt; 4+ open cards scores 6pt
Parity Pairs	3 pairs from 3 different months, all odd or all even	3 open cards scores 3pt; 4+ open cards scores 6pt

15.3 9-point patterns

Pattern	Requirement	Gear
Twin Triples	3 cards of one month and 3 cards of a consecutive month	3 open cards scores 3pt; 4 open cards scores 6pt; 5 open cards scores 9pt

Pattern	Requirement	Gear
Wind Triples	3 cards of one wind and 3 cards of another wind	3 open cards scores 3pt; 4 open cards scores 6pt; 5 open cards scores 9pt
Grand Axis	3 of your seat wind plus 3 of the current round month	3 open cards scores 3pt; 4 open cards scores 6pt; 5 open cards scores 9pt
Tri Tone Triples	3 cards of one month and 3 cards of another month, using at most 3 colors total	3 open cards scores 3pt; 4 open cards scores 6pt; 5 open cards scores 9pt
Parity Triples	3 cards of one month and 3 cards of another month, all odd or all even	3 open cards scores 3pt; 4 open cards scores 6pt; 5 open cards scores 9pt

15.4 12-point patterns

Pattern	Requirement	Gear
Crown	Either: 5 of one month plus 1 neighboring month with all 6 colors present; or 6 of one month with all 6 colors present	0-3 open cards scores 6pt; 4 open cards scores 9pt; 5 open cards scores 12pt
Tempest	All 6 cards are the same wind, as long as it is not your seat wind	0-3 open cards scores 6pt; 4 open cards scores 9pt; 5 open cards scores 12pt
Escort	4 of one month plus 2 matching cards from either the previous or next month, with all 6 colors present	0-3 open cards scores 6pt; 4 open cards scores 9pt; 5 open cards scores 12pt
Split Escort	4 of one month plus 1 previous and 1 next month, with all 6 colors present	0-3 open cards scores 6pt; 4 open cards scores 9pt; 5 open cards scores 12pt
Compass	Four same-color N, S, E, W plus either any month pair or any 2-card month sequence	0-3 open cards scores 6pt; 4 open cards scores 9pt; 5 open cards scores 12pt

15.5 15-point patterns

Pattern	Requirement	Gear
Mono Skip	All 6 cards share one color and are all odd months or all even months	0-3 open cards scores 9pt; 4 open cards scores 12pt; 5 open cards scores 15pt
Mono Run	Six different months in order, all sharing one color	0-3 open cards scores 9pt; 4 open cards scores 12pt; 5 open cards scores 15pt
Grand Crown	All 6 cards are the current round month	0-3 open cards scores 9pt; 4 open cards scores 12pt; 5 open cards scores 15pt

Pattern	Requirement	Gear
Grand Tempest	All 6 cards are your seat wind	0-3 open cards scores 9pt; 4 open cards scores 12pt; 5 open cards scores 15pt
Mono Compass	N, S, E, W plus 2 cards in sequence, all sharing one color	0-3 open cards scores 9pt; 4 open cards scores 12pt; 5 open cards scores 15pt

Notes on the 15-point patterns:

- **Skip** means all odd months or all even months, with all 6 colors and all 6 months different.
- **Run** means a 6-month consecutive run.
- **Mono Skip** means a **Skip** played in a single color lane.
- **Grand Crown** means collecting all 6 cards of the round's target month. In sudden death there is no target month, so **Grand Crown** is unavailable.
- **Axis** means mixing your seat wind with the round's target month in a **2+4** or **4+2** split.
- **Grand Axis** means a **3+3** split between your seat wind and the round's target month.
- **Tempest** means all 6 cards are the same wind, as long as it is not your seat wind.
- **Grand Tempest** means all 6 cards are your seat wind.
- **Compass** uses all four winds in one color plus either any month pair or any 2-month sequence.
- **Mono Compass** uses all four winds plus a 2-month sequence, all in a single color.
- Only **Run** requires any open cards inside that pattern to form a consecutive block of months within the completed run.

16. End of Hand

A hand ends when:

- a player wins by **tsumo**
- one or more players win by **ron**
- the wall is exhausted

If the wall is exhausted:

- the hand is a draw
- no one scores
- dealer rotates normally unless East had won before the draw, which did not happen

17. End of Match

The match ends when one of these happens:

- a player falls to 0 or below
- round 12 ends and one player is alone in first place
- sudden death ends with one player alone in first place

If round 12 ends tied for first:

- no one wins the match yet
- play continues in sudden death rounds until the tie breaks

18. Practical Notes

- Odd/even patterns use the visible month number parity.
- The month labels are numeric 1 to 12 .
- Month order does not wrap; month 12 and month 1 are not neighbors.
- The color labels are abbreviated: G , R , Y , K , B , W .
- The wind labels are abbreviated: N , S , E , W .
- Open-card count matters a lot because of gear. A beautiful hand may still be invalid if it does not meet the required visible open count for its point tier.
- Wind cards have no month and therefore cannot satisfy any pattern requirement that references months, months being consecutive, or month parity.